many of the governments that criticise us are elected to uphold. We are a people's bureau of checks and balances, working internationally, and knowing that the things governments and diplomats do behind closed doors is entirely our business. The people elect them, pay for them, trust them, and are bosses of them. And governments who allow themselves to forget that will hear the voice of the people in every chatroom, on every blog, on every Twitter feed and, eventually, from every square, rising from Tiananmen Square to Tahrir Square, from Trafalgar to Times, with ripples through every letter of the alphabet. And governments who stand against this truth are done for.

Early on in our relationship with the media partners, I knew I would, at some point, offer them the chance to join us in publishing a giant cache of diplomatic cables that had been leaked to us and were being prepared. I was holding off, to let the Afghan and Iraq war logs see the light of day in as measured and careful a way as possible. There was a lot of material, and it takes time to read and sift, organise and present, with legal and other considerations always impinging on the judgements we make. Our chief concern is to keep the promise we make to our sources: if the material fulfils our editorial policy, is important, new, and suffering some form of suppression, we will release it as soon as we can and with all manner of support and fanfare. These latest cables detailed the activities of embassies all over the world; they lifted the lid on secret operations, deep-seated prejudices, national embarrassments and human affairs at every level of government. Like the previous leaks, they would bring the world into focus despite the efforts of those who would prefer it blurred. And they would make a change in our understanding of what our governments were doing, and why.

As a result of the surveillance, and the aggressive attitude of the Pentagon towards me personally, I wanted to make copies of the cables to ensure their safekeeping. I was not happy with how things had developed with the *Guardian*, and thought the *New York Times* were behaving despicably, but my attitude to the former was rather 'better the devil you know'. The *New York Times* had shown themselves to be cowards, however, and I was not ready to work with them again. It felt like there was a massive strike coming down on us, so I copied the 250,000 documents and stashed them first with contacts in Eastern Europe and Cambodia. I also put them on an encrypted laptop and had it delivered to Daniel Ellsberg, the hero of